so, we not only stand up for our own welfare but speak up on behalf of the Global South as well. Indeed, a domestic outlook that so strongly advocates inclusive growth has a natural inclination to display a similar approach abroad. At the same time, we also have an obvious interest along with the rest of the Global South in cooling down overheated global politics. This is obviously not going to happen overnight, yet, we must persevere.

Beyond the immediate compulsions, there are also the structural challenges of the current world order that confront us. Most of those emanate from the outcomes of the Second World War and the fashioning of international architecture in 1945. But they are also underpinned by a few centuries of Western domination, whose intellectual and cultural facets still remain prominent. The oldest trick in the diplomatic book is to freeze the moment to your advantage. This is reflected in cherry-picking events and outcomes and portraying them as the ‘normal’ or in creating mechanisms and concepts that are presented as immutable. That, in fact, is what some countries have done so successfully for the last eight decades. Pursuing reform in the multilateral domain and ensuring that global decision-making reflects democratic reality is, therefore, a quest of no small importance.

Allowing the past to influence thinking is, however, not a predicament that can solely be attributed to others. Sometimes, it is an assumption that we maintain ourselves because a particular experience continues to resonate. Thus, even six decades later, the 1962 war with China stirs suspicion of that country in the public mind. Similarly, our hesitations concerning the West derive from the memories of the 1947, 1965 and 1971 conflicts. This applies even on the positive side of the ledger. The 1991 economic reforms, for example, were impactful enough that the need to build on it was not given priority till recently. Such complacency contributed, till a decade ago, to impassivity towards strengthening manufacturing and developing technologies as well as improving our social indices.

At this stage of its rise, India must have the courage to revisit its past and draw the right lessons from abroad as much as from home. Sometimes, this is misinterpreted as political distancing when it is, in fact, an objective audit. It is not only dangerous to remain a prisoner of our experiences but, even more, to romanticize them. We now have the ability to shape the landscape more significantly and must use that more often. It is already expressed in new concepts like the Indo-Pacific, mechanisms like the Quad